WhatsApp Team Inbox — Guide, Seller Notes & Rollout Tracker

Living document. Update the **Progress tracker** after every step and read it first when resuming.

Progress tracker

Step	What	Status
1	Shared Team Inbox — chat list, conversation, reply (text + file), 24-hour window + template fallback, unread, resolve/reopen, link to Lead/Contact, live refresh	**Built — needs `php artisan migrate` and a live test**
1a	Plan/superadmin gating (`whatsapp_inbox` module) + role permission (`whatsapp.inbox`)	Built
2	Assign conversations, auto-assign (round-robin, off by default), Quick Replies (`/shortcut`), private internal notes, permissions `whatsapp.assign` / `whatsapp.view_all` / `whatsapp.quick_replies`	**Built — needs `php artisan migrate` and a live test**
3	Team performance report, Campaign dashboard (per bulk send), Bulk Send recipient filters (lead status / source)	**Built — needs `php artisan migrate` and a live test**
3b	Broadcast opt-out (STOP / START), automatic Lead from a first WhatsApp message, scheduled bulk sends	**Built — needs `php artisan migrate` and a live test**
4	Product Catalog Sharing	Deferred (needs Meta Commerce Manager catalog + `catalog_management` permission)

Everything still open (go-live checks, step 4, and 11 smaller improvements, each with where-in-code and how-to) is listed in **`docs/whatsapp-pending-and-future-work.md`**.

Known limits (steps 1–2): inbound images/documents show as `[image]` / `[document]` text (the file itself is not downloaded yet); chat is not paused while an agent is replying (the chatbot may still answer keywords); notes cannot be edited or deleted; auto-assign does not look at who is online or on leave; a chat only appears once the customer has written to you.

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1. How a tenant gets the Inbox (superadmin / plans)

The Inbox is a **premium module** named `whatsapp_inbox` ("WhatsApp Team Inbox"), registered in `config/modules.php`. A tenant can use it only if **both** are true:

1. **Module access** — either their **plan includes it**, or superadmin has **switched it on for that tenant**.
2. **Role permission** — the user's role has `whatsapp.inbox` (admins and staff get it by default; to send replies they also need `whatsapp.send`).

Step 2 adds three more role permissions (all need the module to be on first):

Permission	What it allows	Default
`whatsapp.view_all`	See every chat. Without it a person sees only chats assigned to them plus unassigned ones.	Admin + Staff
`whatsapp.assign`	Assign / reassign chats, and change the auto-assign settings	Admin + Staff
`whatsapp.quick_replies`	Add, edit and delete quick replies (everyone with inbox access can *use* them)	Admin only
`whatsapp.view_reports`	Open the **Team performance** report	Admin only
`whatsapp.view_logs` (existing)	Open **Campaigns** (bulk-send results)	as before

To make staff see only their own chats, the owner unticks `whatsapp.view_all` for the Staff role in Settings → Roles.

Without module access the "WA Inbox" menu item is hidden and the URL returns *403 – module is not enabled for your account*.

Option A — sell it as part of a plan Superadmin → **Plans** → edit a plan → tick **WhatsApp Team Inbox** → save. Every tenant on that plan gets it. By default the seeder (`PlanSeeder`) bundles it from the **Pro** plan upward (`tier => pro` in `config/modules.php`); re-run the seeder or tick it by hand for existing plans.

Option B — grant or revoke it for one tenant Superadmin → **Tenants** → open the tenant → **Modules** → toggle **WhatsApp Team Inbox**. This override beats the plan in both directions (grant it on a lower plan as an add-on, or switch it off on a plan that includes it). "Follow plan" removes the override.

Option C — take it away from some staff Tenant owner → **Settings → Roles** → untick `whatsapp.inbox` (view) or `whatsapp.send` (reply) for that role.

The tenant also needs **WhatsApp connected** (WhatsApp → API Settings); otherwise the Inbox shows a warning and cannot send.

2. Using the Inbox (tenant staff)

Menu: **Messages → WA Inbox**.

- **Left side** — your chats, newest first. Tabs: **Open**, **Unread**, **Resolved**, **All** (with counts). Search by name or number. A green badge shows unread messages. The list refreshes itself every few seconds.
- **Right side** — the conversation. Customer messages are on the left, yours on the right (green) with the name of the teammate who sent it. A red bubble means the message failed, with the reason.
- **Reply** — type and press **Enter** (Shift+Enter for a new line). Use to attach an image, PDF, Word or Excel file (up to 16 MB).
- **Mark resolved / Reopen** — resolved chats leave the Open tab. If the customer writes again, the chat reopens by itself.
- **Lead / Contact link** — if the customer's number matches a Lead or Contact, the name shows in the header with a link to the record.

The 24-hour rule. WhatsApp allows free typing only within 24 hours of the customer's last message. After that the box is replaced by an **approved template** picker (available when your number is linked through the WhatsApp gateway). Fill the template fields and send — the customer's reply then reopens the 24-hour window. If no templates are available, ask the customer to message you first.

Assigning chats. Each chat shows who owns it (name in the list, a dropdown in the header). Pick a teammate in the header dropdown to hand the chat over, or "Unassigned" to put it back in the pool. Replying to a chat nobody owns makes it yours automatically. Tabs: **Mine** (open chats assigned to you) and **Unassigned** (open chats nobody owns yet).

Auto-assign (owner). Click **Auto-assign** at the top, tick "Share new chats…" and choose the people. New chats then go to them in turn. A customer who writes again stays with the same person. It is **off by default**; manual assignment always works.

Quick replies. Click ** Quick replies** (admins) to save common answers with a short name, e.g. `price`. In the reply box type `/` and the list appears — use ↑ ↓ and Enter, or click. Write `{{name}}` in the text to insert the customer's first name.

Private notes. Switch the reply box to **Private note**, write, and press Enter. The note appears in the chat as a yellow card and is **never sent to the customer** — use it for hand-over details ("customer wants the 3BHK, call after 5").

Team performance (Messages → WA Performance, owners). Pick Today / Last 7 days / Last 30 days or your own dates. Top cards: customers who wrote in, how many a teammate answered, **average first-reply time**, chats still waiting for a reply, open chats nobody owns. The table shows, per teammate: messages sent, chats replied to, average first reply, and open chats they own right now. Only replies typed by a teammate count — chatbot, automatic and bulk messages are ignored.

Campaigns (Messages → WA Campaigns). Every Bulk Send is one row: when, the message, who sent it, recipients, delivered, failed, success bar. **Details** shows the totals, **why messages failed** (grouped reasons), how many recipients **replied within 3 days**, and every recipient with their status (filter: All / Sent / Delivered / Failed). "Delivered" is filled only for numbers linked through the WhatsApp gateway.

Broadcast opt-out (STOP / START). If a customer replies **STOP** (also *unsubscribe, opt out, stop all*), the CRM adds the number to an opt-out list and sends one short confirmation. From then on that number is **skipped in every bulk send** (it shows as "Opted out" and cannot be ticked in Bulk Send; the result message says how many were skipped). Replying **START** puts them back. Staff can also do it by hand with the **Block broadcasts / Allow broadcasts** button in the chat header. One-to-one replies from the Inbox are never blocked — opting out is about marketing messages. Owners can switch the keyword handling off in **Inbox settings**.

Automatic Lead from WhatsApp. When a number that is not yet a Lead or Contact messages you for the first time, a **Lead** is created (source *WhatsApp*, status *New*, note = their first message, name from their WhatsApp profile) and linked to the chat. If the chat already has an owner (auto-assign) the lead gets the same owner; otherwise the CRM's normal lead auto-assignment applies. Existing leads/contacts are matched by phone number and never duplicated. Owners can switch this off in **Inbox settings** (it is on by default, and only works for tenants with the Inbox module).

Scheduled bulk sends. In Bulk Send choose **Schedule for later**, pick a date and time (2 minutes to 60 days ahead, India time) and press Schedule. The send appears under **Campaigns → Scheduled sends** with a **Cancel** button until it starts. At the chosen time the CRM sends it (a background job runs every minute), skips opted-out numbers, and the result shows up as a normal campaign. If WhatsApp is disconnected at that moment, or the chosen template is no longer approved, the item is marked **Failed** with the reason. Needs the Inbox module.

Bulk Send filters. In WhatsApp → Bulk Send, when sending to Leads you can narrow the list by **status** and **source** (plus the existing search); **Select All** then ticks only the people shown, e.g. "Qualified + JustDial".

Everything sent from the Inbox also appears in **WhatsApp → Logs**.

3. Seller notes

One-line pitch: "Your whole team answers customers from one WhatsApp number — nobody shares a phone, nothing gets missed."

Sell it to: any customer already using WhatsApp for enquiries — real estate, coaching, clinics, salons, service/AMC companies — where more than one person answers chats.

Demo (3 minutes): (1) send a message to the demo number from your phone, (2) show it land in the Inbox with the unread badge, (3) assign it to a teammate, (4) reply with a `/quick reply` and show it on the phone, (5) add a private note, (6) show **Team performance** and a finished **Campaign**, (7) mark resolved.

Pricing / packaging: included from **Pro** by default; can be added to a Starter tenant by superadmin as a per-tenant add-on (Tenant → Modules).

Selling points added in step 3b: compliance (customers can opt out with one word, so numbers are less likely to be blocked), no lead is ever lost (every new WhatsApp number becomes a Lead), and campaigns can be planned in advance.

Don't promise yet: product catalogs, tag-based segments (Leads/Contacts have no tags yet), a separate "read" count in campaigns (only delivered / failed today), re-sending to failed numbers from the campaign page. Be honest that customers' incoming photos/documents show only as a label for now.

Objections: "*Can two people reply at once?*" — yes, both see new messages within seconds, and each reply is stamped with the sender's name. "*Can I stop staff seeing each other's chats?*" — yes, untick `whatsapp.view_all` for that role; they then see only their own and unassigned chats. "*Can chats be shared automatically?*" — yes, auto-assign (round-robin) among the people you choose. "*What if the chatbot is on?*" — the chatbot still answers its keywords; staff can reply on top.

4. Developer notes

- **Data:** table `whatsapp_conversations` (one row per customer number per tenant: `wa_id` digits-only, `status` open|resolved, `unread_count`, `last_message_preview`, `last_message_at`, `last_inbound_at`, `lead_id`, `contact_id`, `assigned_to`). Messages are **not copied** — they are the existing `whatsapp_logs` rows (`status='received'` = customer; anything else = us), matched on digits-only phone (`WhatsappConversation::messages()`).
- **Writes:** `WhatsappInboundService::handle()` calls `WhatsappConversation::touchFor()` for every inbound message — shared by the direct-Meta and the gateway webhook, so both feed the Inbox. This runs for **all tenants**, regardless of module access, so history exists the day a tenant is switched on. Outbound replies are logged by `WhatsappInboxController::reply()`.

- **Gating:** routes in `routes/web.php` under `whatsapp/inbox` use `module:whatsapp_inbox` + `permission:whatsapp.inbox` (reply also `permission:whatsapp.send`). Sidebar link checks both. Plan editor, tenant toggle and PlanSeeder are driven from `config/modules.php`.
- **Permission rollout:** migration `2026_10_13_100000_create_whatsapp_conversations_table` creates `whatsapp.inbox` and gives it to the `tenant_admin` and `staff` roles; the seeder also lists it for fresh installs. Custom tenant roles must be ticked by the owner.
- **Step 2 data:** `whatsapp_conversations.assigned_to` (user id), `whatsapp_quick_replies` (`shortcut` unique per tenant, `body`), `whatsapp_conversation_notes` (private, per conversation), and on `whatsapp_settings`: `inbox_auto_assign`, `inbox_auto_assign_users` (json ids), `inbox_last_assigned_to` (round-robin cursor). Migration `2026_10_14_100000_add_team_features_to_whatsapp_inbox` also creates the three permissions and grants them to the `tenant_admin`/`staff` roles.
- **Visibility rule:** `WhatsappInboxController::scoped()` — without `whatsapp.view_all`, queries add `assigned_to = me OR assigned_to IS NULL`. It is applied to the list, counts, and every single-chat lookup.
- **Auto-assign:** `WhatsappConversation::touchFor()` calls `nextAutoAssignee()` for an inbound message on an unassigned chat; it picks the next active user id after `inbox_last_assigned_to` from the saved list.
- **Notes in the thread:** `timeline()` merges messages and notes sorted by `ts`; the page keeps two cursors (`after`, `after_note`) when polling.
- **Step 3:** `WhatsappInsightsController` (read-only, derived from `whatsapp_logs` / `whatsapp_conversations`; no new tables). Routes `whatsapp/performance`, `whatsapp/campaigns`, `whatsapp/campaigns/{bulkId}` sit behind `module:whatsapp_inbox`; performance needs `whatsapp.view_reports` (new, admin-only via migration `2026_10_15_100000_add_view_reports_permission_to_whatsapp_inbox`), campaigns need `whatsapp.view_logs`.
- **First-reply metric:** logs are walked in id order per customer phone (digits only): an inbound message starts a wait, the next outbound with `sent_by` set (not bulk, not failed) ends it and credits that user. Chatbot messages have no `sent_by`, so they never count. Capped at 100,000 messages per report (`MAX_ROWS`; the page warns when hit).
- **Campaign = `bulk_id`:** `WhatsappController::sendBulk()` stamps every recipient's log with the same uuid. List = `GROUP BY bulk_id`; "replied" = recipients whose number sent a `received` message within 3 days of the first send.
- **Delivery status caveat:** only the gateway webhook updates `delivered`/`failed` and it folds *read* into `delivered`; the direct-Meta webhook (`WhatsappWebhookController`) ignores status events, so on a direct-Meta connection rows stay `sent`. A separate "read" status would need the status enum widened (see migration `2026_10_11_100000`) and the direct webhook extended.

- **Bulk filters:** pure front-end (`applyFilters()` in `bulk.blade.php`, `data-status` / `data-source` on each lead row); the server still receives the ticked recipient ids.
- **Step 3b — opt-out:** table `whatsapp_opt_outs` (`phone` digits, unique per tenant, `source` keyword|manual); model `WhatsappOptOut` has the keyword lists (`STOP_WORDS`, `START_WORDS`; whole message, case-insensitive, punctuation ignored, so "please stop" does **not** match). `WhatsappInboundService::handleOptOut()` runs right after the chat is recorded, for typed text only (never button taps), and replies once. START only acts when the number is on the list, so a chatbot keyword "start" keeps working. `WhatsappBulkSender` skips opted-out numbers. Switch: `whatsapp_settings.optout_enabled` (default on). Runs for **all** tenants, not only the Inbox module.
- **Step 3b — auto lead:** `WhatsappInboundService::autoCreateLead()` — only if the tenant has `whatsapp_inbox`, `whatsapp_settings.auto_create_lead` is on (default on), and the chat has no lead/contact. Duplicates are checked with `DuplicateMatcher` (same as the lead integrations). `Lead::create` fires `LeadCreated`, so the existing `AutoAssignLead` listener works; the chat's `assigned_to` follows the lead's owner.
- **Step 3b — scheduling:** table `whatsapp_scheduled_broadcasts` (recipient ids snapshot, message, template, attachment kept on the private `local` disk under `whatsapp-scheduled/<tenant>/`, `scheduled_for`, `status` pending|processing|sent|failed|cancelled, `bulk_id`, counts). `WhatsappController::sendBulk` → `scheduleBulk()` when `schedule_at` is posted (module-gated, 2 min – 60 days). Command `whatsapp:send-scheduled` (`routes/console.php`, every minute, `withoutOverlapping`) claims each due item with an atomic `pending → processing` update, uploads the attachment, calls `WhatsappBulkSender::run()` (the same code the "send now" path now uses) and records the counts; a `processing` item older than 30 min is marked failed rather than retried (some recipients may already have it). **Production needs `php artisan schedule:run` every minute.** Nothing in `docker/start.sh` starts it, so confirm Voroa runs it (see A11 in `docs/whatsapp-pending-and-future-work.md`) — the existing reminders depend on it too. Cancel: `POST whatsapp/scheduled/{id}/cancel`.
- **Live refresh:** the page polls `GET whatsapp/inbox/poll` every 6 s (list + messages after the last id). No websockets.
- **Deploy:** `php artisan migrate`, then (to bundle it into the stock plans) `php artisan db:seed --class=PlanSeeder`.
- **Files:** `app/Models/WhatsappConversation.php`, `app/Http/Controllers/Web/Tenant/WhatsappInboxController.php`, `resources/views/tenant/whatsapp/inbox.blade.php`, sidebar entry in `resources/views/components/sidebar.blade.php`.